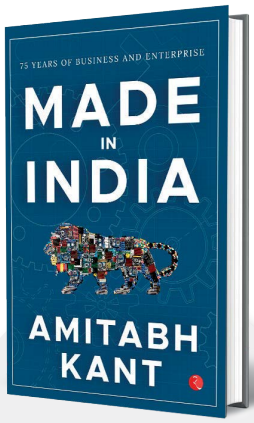
BOOKS

REFORMS IN A NUTSHELL

By M.G. Arun



MADE IN INDIA
75 Years of Business and Enterprise
by Amitabh Kant
RUPA PUBLICATIONS,
₹595; 222 pages

The Narendra Modi government had initiated the Make in India programme as early as 2014, its very first year, with the idea of turning the country into a leading global manufacturing and investment destination. But that wasn't going to be easy. China was still a favourite manufacturing hub for global companies, having greatly improved the quality and scale of its production. However, towards the turn of the decade, a host of events conspired to bring India into the limelight, notably the subsidies war between the US and China, followed by the Covid-19 pandemic. Global manufacturing giants realised the need to further their 'China Plus One' strategy that would insulate their supply chains from disruptions in China. The Modi government plunged right into action to capitalise on this new opportunity. The Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan, launched in May 2022, aimed to create a self-reliant India by fostering its manufacturing capabilities and inviting more global firms to invest here.

There are few better suited to give an insider's account of the reforms in the Modi era than seasoned bureaucrat and G20 Sherpa of India in its presidency year, Amitabh Kant. In his book *Made in India: 75 Years of Business and Enterprise*, Kant first builds the context to these reforms. He dwells on the enterprising quality of India's industrial stalwarts, right from Independence in 1947, as well as major policy decisions that supported them. In that sense, the book is the perfect anthology of past policies in a nutshell—the initial socialist thrust, the phase of extreme state control or 'Licence Raj', the big turning point of liberalisation, the growth years following the stimulus splurge after the 2008 financial meltdown, the policy paralysis at the end of UPA-2, to the present. Those wanting to take a deep dive into each of these policies need to look elsewhere. That's not Kant's idea in the book.

Kant's narrative is lucid, to the point and bereft of jargon, as he skims from one big policy initiative to another, offering a bird's-eye view of events that shaped our economic history. He is also optimistic to a fault, a quality those who know him closely wouldn't be surprised by. He offers rare insights into policymaking when he starts talking about the Modi years, leveraging his access to the PM and two finance ministers—Arun Jaitley and Nirmala Sitharaman. He was secretary to the Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion, and later CEO of Niti Aayog, a post offered to him by Modi when Kant was actually rooting to become chairman of the Competition Commission of India, something which Modi felt he wasn't "cut out" for. Kant's early stints as tourism secretary in Kerala (where he drove the successful God's Own Country campaign) and later as a joint secretary at the Centre (marked by the Incredible India campaign) came in handy during the framing of policies such as Make in India (notably, Modi struck down the idea of an elephant motif for the campaign and suggested a lion, derived from the Ashoka Chakra, instead), the Aspirational Districts programme and Start-Up India, the last of which, he says, helped build "a strong ecosystem for nurturing innovation and entrepreneurship".

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The hallmark of the Atmanirbhar initiative is the production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme wherein manufacturing firms, both global and domestic, are incentivised once targets are met. An area where much headway has been made is handset production, with global companies, including Apple Inc., pushing up their assembly of phones in India.

Kant also counts the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code which made it easier to shut down loss-making businesses, the Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile trinity that helped target subsidies for the poor, Goods and Services Tax, National Infrastructure Pipeline and Unified Payments Interface as big policy successes. The Centre's divestment and asset monetisation policies remain a work in progress. By the time Kant concludes by stressing on future thrust areas like climate change and renewable energy, and frontier technologies such as artificial intelligence, blockchain and drones, he has captured a lot of what is possible in the realm of policymaking, without worrying too much about the equally big challenges. Kant, as always, prefers to see the cup as half full. ■